

The Czardom of Russia

When the Grand Prince of Moscow Ivan IV came to power in 1547, he took the title of “Czar of all Russia”—“czar” meaning “supreme ruler.” Over the next two centuries, Russia expanded its borders and by the time Peter I was proclaimed the first emperor of Russia in 1721, it covered a vast area that stretched across Asia to the Pacific Ocean.

Ivan IV was one of the last monarchs of the Rurik Dynasty, who had established themselves as the rulers of the region surrounding Kiev in 882^{CE} and gradually expanded its territory. When Ivan IV came to power, he reformed local governments and continued to grow the territory of the Duchy of Moscow through military campaigns. The Rurik Dynasty ended when Ivan IV’s son Feodor I died in 1598. A period of chaos followed, which ended when Mikhail Romanov was crowned czar in 1613.

Though the Czardom of Russia was large, it was effectively landlocked, with access to the Baltic Sea

controlled by Russia’s enemy Sweden. Successive czars sought to expand Russian territory to the sea to allow them to develop a powerful navy and provide access to international trade. In 1581, Russia began the slow conquest of Siberia in the east, and in the early 18th century, military victories during the reign of Peter I (“Peter the Great”) and Catherine the Great gained Russia access to the Baltic, Black, and Azov Seas, greatly increasing the power of the czardom.



▲ IVAN THE TERRIBLE

Ivan IV reigned from 1547 to 1584. In the early days of his rule, he carried out much-needed reforms such as setting up the first parliament, the Zemsky Sobor, and revising the code of law. But later, he became increasingly violent, massacring thousands he suspected of being disloyal to him and even killing his eldest son.

FACT

In 1698, in an effort to modernize society on the lines of Western Europe, Peter the Great introduced a tax on beards and robes to get his courtiers to dress like Europeans.

EVERYDAY LIFE

In czarist times, the majority of Russians were serfs—unfree people who worked on the land for their lords in return for a small amount of produce. Like enslaved people, serfs had very limited rights. Serfdom was abolished in Russia in 1861.



▼ EXPANSION OF RUSSIA

From its heartland in eastern Europe, the Russian czardom expanded east into Siberia from around 1600 onward, reaching the Pacific coast in 1649. It also pushed south into Central Asia and the Caucasus, and west into Swedish- and Polish-held territories.

